

With Covid-19 awakening B-schools to the benefits of flexibility in course delivery, and edtechs stepping in, management courses and formats have become even more diversified

MANAGEMENT EDUCATION IN India has evolved and how—starting off as a post-graduate diploma in the 1960s and '70s, to getting a boost from the country's economic liberalisation in the 1990s, to IIMs' MBA degrees coming into play in 2017, to withstanding the Covid-19 disruption of the 2020s, to the current post-Covid-19 hybrid work paradigm that has shaken up the management education 'industry'. Today, an MBA is not necessarily only a two-year programme. Why, you could even do it fully online, if you so wish, albeit its merits are yet debatable.

With Covid-19 awakening B-schools to the benefits of flexibility in course delivery, and edtech firms joining the management bandwagon, the already diverse universe of management courses and formats has further expanded. Today, a student can choose from a one-year MBA (a career pivot tool for a working professional); an executive MBA (shorter programmes designed for experienced professionals to move into leadership roles); a host of online certifications from edtech firms and, of course, the good old full-time two-year MBA. And these courses are being delivered in different ways—on-campus, hybrid, and even fully online.

And so it is that in this 24th edition of the *Business Today* Best B-schools ranking, done in partnership with MDRA since 2013, *BT* has introduced three new categories—India's best one-year MBA programmes, best executive MBA programmes, and the best edtech platforms offering management programmes—in addition to the traditional ranking of two-year MBA courses. (See the rankings starting page 126.) While the traditional ranking is based purely on objective data collected from the B-schools, the other rankings are based on a combination of secondary data plus a perception survey of different stakeholders (see methodology on page 124).

While change is famously the only constant, the pace of change has accelerated in recent times, especially in advanced economies, where questions are being raised about the relevance of two-year management programmes for both students and employers. "The two-year MBA in the US is under severe financial stress," says SPJIMR Dean Varun Nagaraj. Enrolments to schools outside the elite league of, say, Harvard till Carnegie Mellon, are under pressure because their value proposition is not that great beyond a certain ranking. That's why specialised one-year masters are all the rage now there, says Nagaraj. "The new money-spinner for all US business schools is the variety of one-year programmes either in data analytics or business intelligence or supply chain." This was already the case in Europe, says IIM Bangalore (IIMB) Director Rishikesha T. Krishnan, where they don't have too many one-

year MBA courses in general management. "They recognise that in one year, there is only about so much you can do," he says.

But India is different. Here, the two-year MBA serves more as a "mind-expanding finishing school" in the absence of a broad-based liberal arts approach to education, says Nagaraj. "MBAs here have to almost act as the fourth and fifth year of school or college. We should look at it differently [here] than in the US because what precedes the MBA in India is very different." Plus, what serves the two-year MBA's case well in India is its popularity among newcomers to the workforce as a path to well-paying jobs. For instance, XLRI Jamshedpur Director Fr S. George says the institute's XAT 2023 entrance exam received more applications for the two-year programmes than the one-year ones. "The competition for seats for the one-year programmes is comparatively lower than the two-year programmes. Indian MNCs are interested in hiring young professionals—rather than experienced candidates—whom they can groom and mould as per their requirements," he says.

IIM Calcutta (IIMC) Director Uttam Kumar Sarkar says a high percentage of graduates continue to be hired for general management skills. "It's not either/or. We need both the full-time MBA as well as specialised programmes of shorter duration... I can use